she can "cook and test ideas" she has been brewing. Kindling is both a noun and a verb, she notes. "I also like the fact that it has the word kind in it. We are so inured to things that we read and the life we see around us that we feel distanced from the little joys and potential for hope. I think we need more of it in films and life."

Laapataa Ladies also comes at a time when the films that click at the box office are changing. The action spectacle has superseded the small, simple and sensitive narrative, which has resulted in the latter's audience shifting to streaming. Rao though, much like the gone girls in her film, is an optimist. "Audiences do turn up when a story is interesting and they like to be surprised," she says. "Spectacle is not necessarily the only reason they will come. They want to experience a story they will enjoy in some way—make them cry, laugh or keep them on the edge of their seat." She isn't wrong. The acclaim and adulation that Vidhu Vinod Chopra's *12thFail* received last year is proof that there's always room for a film that can buck the trend and make a big impact by doing the basics effectively.

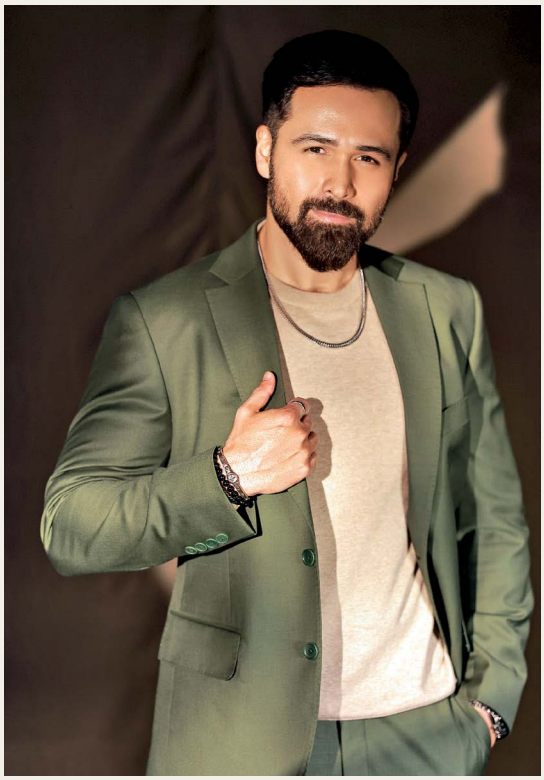
With *Laapataa Ladies,* Rao has succeeded in her mission to "disrupt the traditional commercial film and make it more interesting and exciting". The film has its heart in the right place and a winning message to go with it—"*Sapna dekhne ki maafi nahin maangte* [We don't apologise for dreaming]." It's spurred its creator to not wait for another decade to get into the director's chair again. Now, that's impact. ■

–Suhani Singh

OTT

GAZING INWARDS

The ***Emraan Hashmi****–starrer* Showtime *takes a no-holds-barred look at the Hindi film industry*



Hollywood loves digging into its own past to seek inspiration and hence *The Artist*, *Once Upon a Time in... Hollywood*, *Babylon* to name a few. Bollywood, not so much. Actor Emraan Hashmi, who stars as a film studio honcho in Disney+ Hotstar's *Showtime*, created by Karan Johar's Dharmatic Entertainment, has his theory on the dearth of narratives revolving around the industry. "The writer and director should be a little more inward-searching and objective about the world they belong to and not believe in the myths of what Bollywood is," he says. "Many shy away from the fact that it could be controversial material and [don't want to] ruffle the feathers of the industry they belong to."

Such inhibitions are kept at bay in *Showtime*, which has an array of eccentric characters who are likely to make viewers play guess-the-star reference game. That the series comes from a producer who is in the public eye as much as the stars are makes it all the more noteworthy. Says Hashmi, "Kudos to Karan and Disney for showing a Bollywood no-holds-barred and without any filters."

SHOWTIME has an array of eccentric characters who are likely to make viewers play guess-the-star reference games

Showtime, though, isn't the first web series that delves into the Hindi film industry. Netflix's *desi* version of the popular French series *Call My Agent!* was a dud, while Vikramaditya Motwane's *Jubilee* (on Amazon Prime) offered a compelling portrait of the 1940s pre-Independence studio system, but failed to be greenlit for season two. Where *Showtime* differs is that it doesn't just delve into how the industry functions, but is also able to laugh at its ways. It's best evident in Rajeev Khandelwal's demanding, and a tad delusional, star who makes life difficult for producers. "There are so many things that are wrong as well as right [in the industry], you cannot whitewash it," says Hashmi, whose character Raghu Khanna gets drawn into games of intrigue. "*Showtime* is a good blend of showing all aspects."

To play Raghu, whom Hashmi describes as "a quintessential bad boy", "who has no control over things in his life other than making a film", the actor turned to conversations he has had with peers in both the commercial and creative aspects of the show business. His references also included *Entourage*'s Ari Gold, a ruthless agent played by Jeremy Piven. More than cathartic, Hashmi describes shooting the show as "meta", as the cast went about acting out a part of their daily lives.

Showtime marks Hashmi's second long-format outing after Netflix's *Bard of Blood*. Straddling the theatrical and streaming worlds is the approach he prefers. "With theatrical. one's a little cautious; stories are confined to predictable tropes and safe screenplays and character archetypes," he says. "OTT lets you experiment... I get to play a meatier version of a character." ■

–Suhani Singh